

IT'S SO QUIET OUT HERE. IT IS THE QUIETEST PLACE IN THE WORLD

STALKER / 1979

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Science fiction

DIRECTOR

Andrei Tarkovsky

WRITERS

**Arkady Strugatsky
and Boris Strugatsky
(screenplay and novel)**

STARS

**Alisa Freyndlikh,
Aleksandr Kaydanovsky,
Anatoly Solonitsyn**

BEFORE

1966 Anatoly Solonitsyn stars in Tarkovsky's *Andrei Rublev*, about a medieval iconographer.

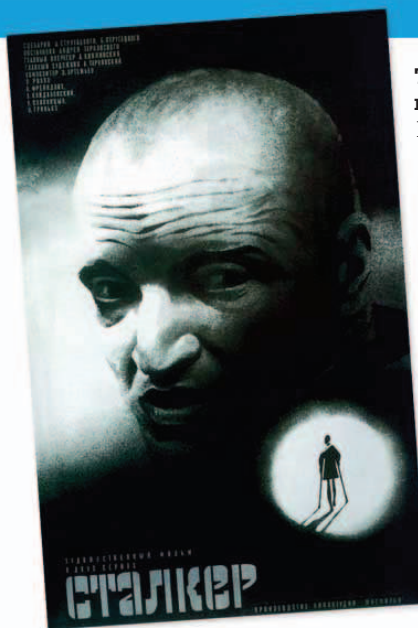
1972 Tarkovsky's movie *Solaris* begins a prolific period.

AFTER

1986 In his final movie, *The Sacrifice*, a man bargains with God to save mankind.

Like all great artists, Russian director Andrei Tarkovsky was often asked where he found the ideas for his movies. Tarkovsky himself, however, did not think the topic of inspiration was really much of a point for discussion. "The idea of a film," he once said, "always comes to me in a very ordinary, boring manner, bit by bit, by rather banal phases. To recount it would only be a waste of time. There is really nothing fascinating, nothing poetic, about it."

Tarkovsky's pessimistic view of art in general might also seem surprising. "It is obvious that art cannot teach anyone anything," he said, "since in 4,000 years humanity has learned nothing at all."



The movie's meaning has been endlessly discussed since it first came out. Tarkovsky himself refused to be drawn in.

It is worth mentioning these things since they go some way in explaining the director's own, oblique attitude to

his art, which he discussed himself in his 1986 book *Sculpting In Time*, its title the perfect metaphor for his cinematic technique. A Tarkovsky movie is in some ways like a piece of sculpture by British artist Henry Moore: the abstractions mean as much as the realities, and what is left out often has as much significance as the elements that remain.